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Ruth Brisbane

Ruth Brisbane is a veteran stage actress and accomplished blues and jazz vocalist. Her Broadway credits include "The Wiz" and "South Pacific" and she created and starred in a one-woman show entitled "The Legacy of Bessie Smith." Ruth appeared in the Paris production of "Black and Blue" and currently performs regularly with the Harlem Blues and Jazz Band.

Ruth was interviewed in Clinton, NY on April 2, 2013, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive. Her husband, Milt Robinson, participated briefly in the interview.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive today with Ruth Brisbane. Welcome to Hamilton.

RB: Great to be here.

MR: I so much enjoyed your singing today, and I was struck by — as we talked beforehand — you have a normal-sounding speaking voice, but when you sang, man, that delivery was so powerful.

RB: Really. Oh thank you.

MR: Is that a conscious change for you?

RB: I have no idea whether it's a conscious change. I was not formally trained so I guess it's what they'd call "belting it out."

MR: Belting it out. Yeah.

RB: Yeah. I think today I mentioned that my mother sang, and she was a tiny lady but she could belt it out, yes.

MR: What kind of songs would she have sung around the house?

RB: Around the house she loved Bessie Smith, and the heyday of her era was the Blues Era. She was born in 1900. So in the twenties she would have been in the twenties, a young woman. She was married and had children — a brood — with my dad. And she loved the blues. In fact, when I started singing she said you've got to learn a blues. I didn't know a blues from, you know swing or whatever. I was listening to people like Ella and Dinah, and well Dinah was a good blues singer, but I couldn't differentiate blues and swing. And I wasn't doing any blues. But my mother forced me to learn blues.

MR: That's very interesting. I've read that some African-American households thought blues was the devil's music, or something like that.

RB: Uh huh. Well people who are religious, yeah. They didn't want it played and so forth. And listening to some of the old songs – they could be quite spicy.

MR: So for you, when she said, "You need to sing some blues" was part of that the blues song with the three lines, the first two being the same, and was that part of the definition of a blues or was it more about feel?

RB: No, I believe the standard blues, yes. Standard blues.

MR: And so who did she direct you to, to be a blues model?

RB: Who did she direct me to. She really did not direct me to any model, but I had a sister-in-law who was divorced from my brother but she took an interest in my singing. And she sent me to a vocal coach. And he was mainly blues and R&B, and mainly gave me songs that he had written. So still, getting the standard blues, I had to work on getting that myself.

MR: I see. And when your mom listened to records, were they LPs?

RB: Well LPs hadn't even come out then. The house was always loaded with music because I have older brothers and sisters, and my mother wanted to know where they were so they were allowed to have company so there was always music and people, young people. So whatever was the latest tunes were being played around the house. But my mother could play piano, whatever she heard.

MR: Oh, she was a person who could just hear it and then —

RB: Yes, right. She had an ear. Her father played cornet in, I guess, minstrel bands. Yes. But her mother was a singer also, and I don't know, on the road. My mother was raised by some aunts. But the music was in her, and I guess it came from the womb. And she imparted it to us. My father had no rhythm and couldn't hold a tune.

MR: Really?

RB: Yes.

MR: How interesting. Was he mystified by your interest in music and thinking of it as a career? How did he feel about that?

RB: Well he didn't — he died so he really didn't get to see me fulfill my career. And he was so busy working.

MR: Oh. What did he do?

RB: He was a mechanic. During the war, a longshoreman.

MR: And you grew up in Brooklyn.

RB: I grew up in Brooklyn, yes.

MR: Was there a certain age, when you were a teenager or whenever, when you were really thinking — well let me rephrase the question. Was there a point where you thought I could really make a living being an entertainer?

RB: No. I was sort of like in limbo. I sort of dropped into singing. As I said, my sister-in-law sent me to a coach to get an act, AK, at a very good piano player and old football player.

first professional job by an agent. He was a former football player. I'm sorry, Monk, it will come to me. Fritz Pollard.

MR: Fritz Pollard?

RB: Fritz Pollard. That was his name. He had an office on 125th Street. He sent me up to New Haven, Connecticut. I remember working there and getting the train from his office on 125th. And while I was working in this little black club up in New Haven, who comes in but Lionel Hampton. And he had me audition the next day at the theater he was working in. And I was so stupid. He said, "Stay and take the bus back with me, I want to talk to you about going into the Apollo with us." But I already had my train ticket so I went home on the train, and when I went to the Apollo his band boy stopped me and tried to make himself into something else. You know what I mean. So I left. No nonsense. But anyway, I missed that opportunity working with Lionel Hampton. But I had opportunities that I didn't even take, but I got dropped into music, that's what I'm trying to say. It was nothing that I planned. Nothing that I planned.

MR: It seems like I've heard stories about Lionel Hampton's band boys somewhere else. Some people might not even know what a "band boy" is.

RB: He wasn't a boy, he was an older man. But I guess they see that everything's running right, getting the musicians together.

MR: You mentioned in passing almost that when you went to, was it New Haven you said, that it was a black club. Does that mean that white people couldn't go there or just didn't go there?

RB: Oh, they went, they went. But it was black-owned and in a black area. Yes.

MR: And was there dancing?

RB: Dancing yes, and the band and an emcee singer. And the usual exotic dancers.

MR: And you said that you went to this person to get an act together.

RB: Yes.

MR: That's sort of the responsibility of a singer, right? If you want to work you should have some kind of —

RB: You're supposed to have an act, which I didn't realize at the time. An act? You get up and sing you know. But I had it and so forth, and then he would correct me, "No, no, I don't want that Sarah Vaughan ending, I want a straight ending" or something like that on a song. And I helped pick out songs in sequence.

MR: And did he go through and get your keys for you?

RB: Oh yes. Your keys and he was very good for helping you with interpretation.

MR: And did you carry music with you? Like lead sheets to give to —

RB: They would write up lead sheets, yes, they would, I forgot about that, yes.

MR: Well when you went to this — we are talking a lot about that one gig, but I'm sort of curious, did you know any of the musicians before you got there?

RB: I knew none of the musicians. In fact when you say that, I had a job where Meharry Medical School is, I think it's Memphis. And a lot of the musicians were from the medical school. Excellent musicians. Yeah. But they were in school, they were in medical school.

MR: And after you did some of the singing, how did you get into the theater?

RB: Well I wanted to audition for theater for years, but I heard that you had to read music. And I did not read music. I didn't study piano or sight singing. I started sight singing courses sometimes and then I'd drop out because I had to go somewhere out of town or whatever. And finally I got up enough nerve to audition for an off-off-Broadway show. And I ended up getting a part in it. It was like a "Hair." And we rehearsed up in Bucks County in a barn, and slept in the barn. So it did end up in New York at St. Clements Theater, which is good for off-Broadway shows. It's still in existence. And in fact some of the gentlemen I worked with up there, one was in the opening of and for a long time, "Lion King," which is still on Broadway, and movies another one. I was watching him in a movie the other night, another young man who was in the play that we were in, called "Walk on the Clouds."

MR: And about what year would that have been?

RB: That was in the sixties, late sixties, yes late sixties.

MR: And you said your future husband came up and said, "What are you doing in this barn?"

RB: Yes. He was so shocked. How could you?

MR: That's called paying dues, isn't it?

RB: I would say it was paying dues. You still had fun because you were with musicians, singers, and this was getting a show from the very beginning, not coming into a show that's already running and getting a part. And the directors and musicians were all hair in quotes type.

MR: What does that mean to you? Hair in quotes type.

RB: Well very Bohemian I would say, to use a word, a phrase, "Bohemian," invoking that era when liberation, they called it liberation.

MR: In that era sure, the sixties.

RB: The sixties, yes.

MR: Well that was also an era of great soul music and Motown. Did that music catch your ear? Did you enjoy that kind of music? James Brown?

RB: I heard of James Brown once — I mean not once but — I kept hearing about James Brown. I don't know why I hadn't heard him. But he was at the Apollo Theater on 125th

with the coat and everything, and the band. They all had a part doing something. And it was a repetitive show, but he had a long line around. I said what do I know? Boys, look at this. But the Motown sound came to me kind of late. And I say that because I had two younger sisters that I used to take to the Motown shows — Stevie Wonder and so forth — at the big theaters in Brooklyn and in Manhattan. And I could not get into it at the time.

MR: And you worked in Paris. Was that with "Black and Blue?"

RB: Black and Blue, yes.

MR: What was that like, being in Paris and getting paid to do what you like?

RB: Oh it was wonderful, wonderful. I love Paris and as the song says "I Love Paris." And it was the wintertime. It opened in December. One of the leads, she had work to do in New York, or concerts to do. And she wanted to go out and do the concerts and come back, but they said no, if you leave, you know, you're turning it over to someone else. So I auditioned and I worked with so many wonderful musicians. The best part of working "Black and Blue" was like Claude "Fiddler" [Williams], Bill Dillard, I'm trying to think of some of the other names. Oh, the tap dancers, the older tap dancers, the Copasetics.

MR: The Copasetics?

RB: Yes, have you heard of them?

MR: No.

RB: They were older gentlemen who danced, tap danced. And they were like mentors to, if you mentioned the Copasetics. In fact Billy Strayhorn — he didn't dance, he wrote — but he was part of that club, the Copasetics. But the Copasetics were a group of dancers. There is a movie out, it's an older movie, and they all have a part in it. I think Sammy Davis is in the movie, I can't think of the name. I saw it again recently on TV. I'll do some research and write you and let you know.

MR: Were you a member of the union?

RB: SAG? No not SAG, Actor's Equity. Yes. I was a member of the Actor's Equity, and also if you do commercials you have to join SAG. So I did a few SAG commercials, which is Screen Actors' Guild. And a few little bits in movies. You'll see me at the beginning of Cotton Club with the Hines Brothers, for a flash.

MR: You're lucky you didn't end up on the cutting room floor I guess.

RB: Well there was more than that that did end up on the cutting room floor, yeah.

MR: Do you recall what kind of commercials you did?

RB: I did a Hershey's commercial, an automobile, I'm trying to think which one it was, I think it was Chevrolet. That was radio though. And I'm trying to think of some of the other commercials I did.

RB: Usually it's one day. Yes. You go in and audition and then you might have to come back for wardrobe and fittings and so forth. And then you shoot.

MR: And they give you a little script for a thirty second commercial?

RB: Yes. Holding the product, Bounty or whatever. I think I did do a Bounty.

MR: Wow. I'll look for it.

RB: That was long ago, in the seventies.

MR: Do you remember what those things would pay, if you don't mind my asking?

RB: Very, very well.

MR: Really, no kidding.

RB: If it goes national, excuse me. I remember the key word was nationally. Yes, if it goes national it pays very, very well.

MR: And do you keep getting —

RB: Residuals, yes. Until they take it off. And sometimes they want to renew it so you get another stipend when they went to renew it.

MR: That's probably pretty neat when the check shows up for something all those years ago.

RB: Yes, yes.

MR: How did you get hooked up with Dr. Vollmer and the Harlem Blues and Jazz Band?

RB: I was doing a show with a gentleman named Terry Waldo, who specializes in ragtime music and all the old tunes. And he studied with Eubie Blake and I think he worked on some of his music categorizing it or cataloguing it. And Terry was doing a show where Shea Stadium was, the old World's Fair was there, one of the old World's Fairs. And it was called "Shake That Thing." Why do I have to be in shows like "Shake That Thing" and "One Mo' Time." So I was part of the show and Al saw me in that and called me to substitute for his singer, who was quite busy. She loved to go out and do other things. And she stayed busy. So they were downtown in the Village at a club, and I worked there a few times for Al, for Al's band. Al might not have even been there. That's how I started working with him.

MR: And is it my, am I right in guessing that there was probably no rehearsal?

RB: No. No rehearsals. Hit it. Yeah, uh huh.

MR: So if a young singer is watching this interview, what do you say to that person? How do they prepare to do that kind of thing, where they get a call to show up at some club and be ready to work?

RB: Well you have to have your keys or your lead sheet, as you said, it reminded me about the lead sheets that are written out in your key. And hopefully the piano player reads or whoever leads. And try to get out there and work as much as you can to get some kind of experience, so you'll be ready to sing along with people who work in bigger venues or

MR: Was there an experience when you were young that you recall where you really got thrown in front of an audience where you had to really suck it up and — I think you mentioned something about your —

RB: I was not ready. I was telling about how my mother was active in the community and at BAM, which is very famous now, Brooklyn Academy of Music, every year the Ladies' Club, the "Amsterdam News" which is the black newspaper, Fresh Air Fund Benefit, they would cook, make magnificent food, go out and get cases of beer and booze for backstage musicians who donated the time. The whole Apollo would come over. I guess they must have heard about the good food and booze. And Eubie Blake was conducting, and Noble Sissle. And my mother made me get up and sing. I was not ready. Not ready at all.

MR: And how old were you then?

RB: Oh, maybe about 15. I would think about 15, if that. Yeah. At least about 14 or 15.

MR: Do you remember what you sang?

RB: I think I sang a song that you mentioned, "All of Me." Yes.

MR: Well it's funny when you said you weren't ready, that's what you said, you might have wondered, well when would you be ready, in your own mind.

RB: In my own mind I had never been sent to a coach or didn't realize the significance of having your lead sheets or your keys, things like that. So it took a good while before I got to a coach or someone to assist me, or to go to someone to pay them to get an act.

MR: What did you usually make on a — I'm just curious about the pay musicians got and how, if you lined it up with what people were making for an hourly wage, and the cost of living and that whole thing. What was an average gig paying for you?

RB: Well when I started singing an average gig was like about 15 dollars a night at the local venues. And I'm very vague about how that added up in that time. But I can remember making 15 dollars a night. And I think that wasn't too bad because I think a full time job was paying something like 20, 25 dollars a week, say for a secretary.

MR: So 15 a night wasn't too bad.

RB: It wasn't too bad. You worked two nights on the weekend, that was 30 dollars.

MR: Did you have to learn how to handle yourself with some of the clientele or even some of your fellow musicians, as a young woman. I forgot the name you were calling, you were trying to call some of these clubs.

RB: Oh, "bucket of blood."

MR: "Bucket of blood," yes.

RB: Well I stayed very uptight. I started off in some very nice ones, but a couple of times some people called, like an emcee, "Ruth come work with me." And, "Oh my God that's

nervous. And then one night what relaxed me is that I went in one night to a club I did not want to work in. And there was this gorgeous woman at the door collecting money. Elegant, dressed gorgeous, she became one of my best friends. And that relaxed me so I was no longer afraid to work in any bucket of blood. But how I handled myself, I was always a little nervous and a little — you know my mother put the fear of everybody in us you know. Don't do this, don't do that. My sister-in-law, who was the exotic dancer, don't do this, don't do that, stand this way, blah blah. So I was always a little uptight, but I handled myself very well.

MR: I like your description of a typical act, the full act in a club would consist of an exotic dancer, the singer and the emcee, and a comedian.

RB: No, the emcee was a comedian, the exotic dancer, the singer and of course the house band. And like in Brooklyn when my sister-in-law called me for the Baby Grand in Brooklyn and Nipsey Russell was the emcee.

MR: Nipsey Russell.

RB: Yes. And he was quite famous. He was quite famous then, and a wonderful emcee. I was afraid for him to even say boo to me like "hello" — this is Nipsey Russell. So that's what I mean about being uptight. But my sister-in-law always said, "You don't do anything but sing for a living, you have a wonderful voice. You sing and don't take any nonsense from anybody." And my mother instilled that in me too so I never did. I'd walk out. You'd go to an agent's office that's hanky panky, goodbye. You don't even say goodbye.

MR: And what would define an exotic dancer? What made them exotic?

RB: Their costumes. It was in quote stripping. But they had an act. It was really hilarious and I'd love to see on Sanford & Son, his cousin or, she used to be an exotic dancer. She was very funny, the woman. I can't think of her name. And I heard that she used a snake. Yes. She was a snake charmer. That was her hook. My sister-in-law stripped from a costume that was — and music too — "The Last Time I Saw Paris." And she came out in a couture suit and from there she stripped, which she was a gorgeous woman, beautiful. And very classy. She had a very classy act.

MR: Did you get to sing before or after the stripper?

RB: The stripper was usually on in the middle, yes. And the emcee and comedian would come out and tell the jokes at the beginning and then more, and I think the singer usually was last.

MR: And how many shows did you do a night?

RB: Oh at least three or four.

MR: So the hours typically would have been —

RB: From about ten to four in the morning. From ten P.M. to four in the morning. And in New

MR: And how would you get home after that?

RB: Believe it or not I'm amazed when I worked in Manhattan, all the way up to 125th, I took the subway home. I can't imagine doing that today, or twenty years ago I couldn't imagine doing that. And I had six blocks to walk from the subway in Brooklyn. I remember falling asleep on the train one night and Diahann Carroll's father woke me up. He was a conductor on the A train, and that's the train I took home to Brooklyn. And he woke me up and he said, "I believe you get off soon." I will thank that man forever. Because I would never went past my stop which was Utica Avenue in Brooklyn, and I really would have been upset, more than upset. But my mother used to say if you ever feel that you have to take a cab home, even if you don't have the money, we'll find the money in the house somewhere to pay the cab driver.

MR: Yeah, so those are some pretty late nights and you can watch the sun come up almost.

RB: Yeah.

MR: Now were you ever playing clubs and then having a day job at the same time?

RB: Yes, yes.

MR: That must have been hard.

RB: It was. And my supervisor said, "You have to make a choice." I was working in King's County Hospital in Brooklyn in the Student Nurses' Department typing up the tests and lectures and things. And I was doing a lot of work. And so she said it's not good for your health and so forth. She was giving me good advice. I don't think it was because of my capabilities at work, but she had had tuberculosis years ago, remember, tuberculosis was a big killer. And she was from Pennsylvania. She was the head of the little office I was in. And I think she was just giving me good advice. And then I had some jobs that I was offered out of town, so I handed in my resignation.

MR: This is a hard question but I'll try it. Do you recall any of the worst gigs you ever had to play?

RB: I'm trying to think. I think after, even if they're the worst after you can laugh about it, so they turn into something that's not the worst gig. I know that sometimes on New Year's Eve can be some of the worst gigs. I remember working in a club where there was nowhere to sit. I had to sit on the bench with the organ player ,with the organist, and there wasn't anywhere for the performers to sit.

MR: Okay. How about the best gigs? A couple of the best gigs you ever had.

RB: Well as I said, I loved working in "South Pacific" for some reason. I loved "South Pacific," being Bloody Mary. And of course the show had a message so that was even more of a plus.

MR: What was the song that you got to sing as Bloody Mary?

RB: There was two [sings] Talkin' talkin' happy talk; and then my favorite one was [sings] Most people live on a lonely island/Lost in the middle of a foggy sea/Most people long for another/I wonder where they wish/They long to be/Bali hai/May call you. Yeah I love that song. Maybe that's why I loved it so much, I love "Bali Hai." It's magical. And a big cast, a huge cast, and it was fun. But I'm sure I've had better gigs and I've had as much fun, but that one always resonates with me.

MR: And what theater was that in?

RB: We did a Midwest tour of it, but ended up in a dinner theater in Nanuet.

MR: Nanuet?

RB: Nanuet, New York. But we started out in Muni Opera, which was outdoors sometimes, and I remember the big trees, huge stage, and you opened your mouth and the bugs were flying in al of us in the cast. I think Giorgio Tozzi and Florence Henderson, and we all were complaining about the bugs. Then we went to Indianapolis and the Starlight Theater, another Starlight Theater. But we ended up in Nanuet, New York.

MR: With Julius LaRosa?

RB: Julius — that was a different one.

MR: Now you said the Muni Opera?

RB: The Muni Opera is a huge — I guess it's from municipal opera. I'm not sure if it's run by the city of St. Louis. It's a huge venue in a park.

MR: And you probably would have had a fairly large pit orchestra in those days.

RB: Oh yes.

MR: Those groups have shrunk now, a lot of them, for the touring. And have you traveled overseas with the Harlem Blues and Jazz Band?

RB: Oh yes. We've been to Sweden practically every year, and Norway. Another magical job was in — oh God, it's a tourist place in Denmark. Oh what is it? Sorry, the memory. But that was magical. Beautiful little theater in a park. What is the name? Please forgive me. I don't want to tell you what it is — early Alzheimer's.

MR: Well the audiences, are they different overseas?

RB: I think they are different. I would say they're different. They're very receptive. Not only there, we've been to Russia several times, traveled all over, from one end to the other, which Russia is huge from the east coast to the west coast. You could look over and see China from Vladivostok or whatever the heck it is. But I'm still trying to think of the name of that theater.

MR: Tivoli Gardens?

RB: Tivoli Gardens? I think it is — no Tivoli is in England, right?

MR: [Ruth's husband] Escapes me too.

MR: [Ruth's husband] Yeah. But I have to pay my way.

RB: He's been a few times, yeah. Yeah, it's been lovely working with the Harlem Blues and Jazz Band, yeah. The last place we went was Macau, that was so rewarding, we had such a wonderful time. And outside. We had to land in Hong Kong, then take a ferry to the Macau. Lovely, lovely place. I had a wonderful time.

MR: It must be hard to decide what you have to charge in order to pay everybody and pay all those plane tickets and all that.

RB: Yes, yes. It's a lot of money for the people to put out who bring us over there. Yes. Oh and another place, St. Petersburg, oh my God is that a beautiful city in Russia. And we've done in theater there and outside in the park. It was really wonderful.

MR: Have you ever done any attempts at writing your own songs?

RB: Yes I have. And I think I've been lazy. In fact I was just asked if I knew anybody who writes lyrics. I can attempt to write some more. Yes. If I put my mind to it.

MR: So if a young singer comes to you these days and says, "You know I want to do some of the stuff that you did in your career." Do you have any advice for them?

RB: I certainly would. I would advise them to be more on top of what they are aiming for or their goals. And I've had — I wouldn't say a lackadaisical attitude — but I knew I could always stop and go and work as a secretary and make a good — I've worked at the United Nations. When I went up to the barn, in the first play I went into, I was working at the William Morris Agency getting a very, very good salary. So I've been, you know, like on the fence too much. Too much on the fence. I think straight ahead music would be better concentrating on your music, yes.

MR: Be very directed.

RB: Be very directed at what you are aiming for.

MR: Now your husband says he plays a lot of jazz in the house.

RB: Yes.

MR: And what is your favorite era?

RB: His favorite era or mine?

MR: His.

RB: His favorite era is he loves Duke Ellington, Monk, Coltrane, some of them — when we first got married he first bought an album, "Bitches Brew." I said, "You've got on 'Britches Brew' again." He would turn me into a — but you know now I like, when I heard it played on the radio. I say, "Oh, that's 'Bitches Brew' and I love it."

MR: I'll be darned.

RB: And he loves crazy people like Ornette Coleman. Some of the CDs he has, please, I don't want to hear that again.

MR: Yeah, I have some of those memories. The first Coltrane album I bought I was unaware of what he was doing, and it was called "Om." And it was very, very progressive. My ears were not ready for it yet.

RB: You'll have to play that one for me, Milton.

MR: Well — and what do you like to listen to?

RB: What do I like to listen to. Well I love, I love, I want to concentrate more on Brazilian music. Love sambas, and that type of music. And as I said, I still enjoy the older singers. When I say older, the ones I grew up with listening to: Ella and Sarah. You played them and you'd say wow, listen to the way they were singing then.

MR: Do you consider yourself a scat singer?

RB: No, but I do scat. I do scat. And I have to get in the mood for it. I scat around the house and stuff.

MR: What's your next gig? You guys are going to Europe I think, or remind me, I may be confused.

RB: Yes, they're going to Europe. I'm not going because I'm recuperating from my back surgery. So it would be a stretch for me.

MR: Well I loved the way you sang the gospel songs earlier today. Very powerful.

RB: Oh, thank you, thank you.

MR: And I'm looking forward to your performance tonight. Do you have any, just quickly, any people you've been able to play with over the years and meet, that you'd like to say anything about?

RB: Well the only thing I'd like to say is people I've met and could've worked for and didn't take the opportunity, like working with Lionel Hampton's band. I had an audition with Duke and got cold feet. They were recording. Someone he was working with said, "Come up to the recording." I came but I left. I got cold feet. That's somebody I really would love to have worked with. And I think I got overwhelmed by the thought of Duke Ellington you know.

MR: Well I appreciate your time today. Thank you very much for your conversation.

RB: Any time, if you'd like an addendum, let me know.

MR: I look forward to your performance tonight.

RB: Well thank you.

MR: Thanks a lot.